

Research in Progress:

### **Filtering the Feed: Out-Party Affect and Perceived Partisan Exposure on Facebook**

#### **Abstract**

This study examines whether perceived partisan content exposure on Facebook is shaped by pre-existing out-party affect and whether such exposure is associated with post-election candidate evaluations. Using panel data from the ANES 2020 Social Media Study ( $N = 3,123$ ), analyses suggest that prior out-party affect predicts reported exposure, and that perceived exposure is associated with lower post-election out-party evaluations. The project considers whether partisan content environments are partly perceptual and affect-driven rather than purely informational.

*Keywords:* selective exposure, affective polarization, perceived exposure, social media, out-party affect, political communication

## **Purpose and Significance**

Research on partisan media exposure typically treats exposure as an independent input into political judgment (Guess et al., 2021; Levendusky, 2013; Stroud, 2008). Yet in social media environments, exposure is often captured through self-reports, making it difficult to disentangle actual encounters with content from the prior attitudes and predispositions that shape exposure selection and perception (Dvir-Gvirsman et al., 2016; Prior, 2009; Slater, 2007). This project examines whether pre-existing out-party affect helps structure perceived partisan content exposure on Facebook and whether such perceived exposure is associated with post-election candidate evaluations.

This question is important because much of political communication research assumes that media environments shape attitudes, while giving less attention to the possibility that prior affect also shapes how those environments are perceived and reported. If perceived exposure is partly driven by out-party hostility, then some apparent exposure effects may also reflect affect-based attention, interpretation, and recall (Garrett et al., 2016; Taber & Lodge, 2006; Vallone et al., 1985). By shifting attention from exposure as a purely external force to exposure as a potentially affect-conditioned perception, this study seeks to refine how scholars understand selective exposure, affective polarization, and political information processing on social media (Stroud, 2010; Taber & Lodge, 2006).

## **Theoretical Framework and Literature Grounding**

This project draws primarily on research on selective exposure and affective polarization. Selective exposure research suggests that individuals gravitate toward politically congenial information, while work on affective polarization highlights the central role of out-party hostility in shaping political judgment and social evaluation (Iyengar et al., 2019; Stroud, 2010; Taber &

Lodge, 2006). These traditions suggest that prior affect may shape not only what people encounter, but also how they interpret and report their political information environments (Goldman & Mutz, 2011; Gunther & Schmitt, 2004; Scharkow, 2016).

This possibility is especially important in social media settings, where exposure is often measured through self-reports rather than direct observation. In such contexts, reported exposure may reflect not only actual encounters with political content but also affect-driven attention, interpretation, and recall (Prior, 2009). Individuals with stronger negative evaluations of the out-party may be more likely to perceive and report candidate-related content as out-party exposure (Perloff, 2015; Taber & Lodge, 2006). This possibility is consistent with scholarship showing that social media environments can expose users to politically diverse content while also leaving substantial room for selective perception and interpretation (Bakshy et al., 2015; Messing & Westwood, 2014).

This perspective shifts attention from exposure as a purely external input to exposure as a potentially perceptual and affect-conditioned construct. In doing so, it provides the theoretical basis for examining whether pre-existing out-party affect helps structure perceived partisan content exposure on Facebook and how such perceived exposure is associated with later candidate evaluations.

***RQ1:** How is pre-election out-party affect associated with perceived out-party candidate content exposure on Facebook?*

***H1:** Perceived out-party candidate content exposure on Facebook will be negatively associated with post-election out-party trait evaluations, controlling for pre-election out-party affect.*

***H2:** Pre-election out-party affect will moderate the association between perceived out-party exposure and post-election out-party trait evaluations, such that the relationship between pre-election and post-election out-party evaluations becomes weaker among respondents reporting out-party exposure.*

***RQ2:** Do similar patterns emerge for perceived in-party candidate content exposure and post-election in-party trait evaluations?*

## **Methodology**

Data come from the ANES 2020 Social Media Study, which includes pre-election and post-election panel surveys of U.S. adults. The analysis focuses on respondents with usable post-election weights and examines links between pre-election candidate affect, self-reported exposure to candidate-related Facebook content, and post-election candidate trait evaluations.

The project focuses primarily on partisan respondents, for whom in-party and out-party targets can be clearly defined. Pre-election affect is measured using candidate feeling thermometers, and post-election candidate evaluation is captured with trait-based measures for Donald Trump and Joe Biden. Reported exposure is based on respondents' self-reports of encountering candidate-related content on Facebook during the pre-election wave. Parallel in-party and out-party measures are constructed relative to respondents' partisan direction.

Weighted regression models with robust standard errors are used to estimate these associations. Baseline-adjusted specifications account for pre-election evaluations, allowing for a more conservative assessment of whether reported exposure is associated with post-election candidate evaluations net of prior affect. The analytic sample reflects listwise deletion across variables included in the models, and additional checks using alternative specifications yield substantively similar patterns.

## Preliminary Results

Preliminary analyses suggest that pre-election out-party affect is significantly associated with reported exposure to out-party candidate content on Facebook. Across both linear and logistic specifications, respondents with more negative pre-election evaluations of the out-party candidate were more likely to report encountering out-party candidate content on Facebook ( $b = -0.020, p = .022$ , linear model;  $b = -0.083, p = .014$ , logistic model). Reported out-party exposure is, in turn, negatively associated with post-election out-party trait evaluations, controlling for baseline affect ( $b = -0.051, p = .015$ ).

A significant interaction further indicates that reported out-party exposure conditions the relationship between pre-election and post-election out-party evaluations ( $b = -0.073, p < .001$ ). More specifically, reported out-party exposure appears to attenuate the positive carryover from pre-election out-party affect to post-election out-party trait evaluation. Even among respondents with relatively more positive pre-election evaluations of the out-party candidate, those reporting out-party exposure tended to show lower post-election out-party trait evaluations than those not reporting such exposure (see Figure 1).

[Figure 1 about here]

By contrast, the in-party pathway appears weaker and less theoretically informative. Although reported in-party exposure is positively associated with post-election in-party evaluations ( $b = 0.162, p < .001$ ), the interaction between pre-election out-party affect and reported in-party exposure is not statistically significant ( $b = 0.007, p = .842$ ). Taken together, these preliminary findings suggest that prior affect may be especially important for shaping how out-party content is perceived and related to later candidate evaluations.

## Expected Contributions

This project contributes to political communication research by arguing that what appears to be partisan exposure may partly reflect affect-conditioned reporting rather than exposure alone. By shifting attention away from a simple input-output model of media effects, it reconceptualizes self-reported partisan exposure as a construct that may be shaped not only by the content people encounter, but also by the affective orientations they bring to that environment.

This perspective extends research on selective exposure, affective polarization, and social media by highlighting the possibility that partisan content environments are not only informational but also perceptual. In this view, some apparent exposure effects may also capture affect-driven attention, interpretation, and recall.

More broadly, the findings underscore the distinctive importance of out-party dynamics. The strongest pattern in the current analyses appears on the out-party side, suggesting that prior affect may be especially consequential for shaping how out-party content is perceived and how those perceptions are linked to later candidate evaluations.

### **Areas Needing Feedback**

This project would benefit from feedback on four issues. First, should perceived partisan content exposure be conceptualized primarily as a perceptual construct rather than as a behavioral indicator of exposure? Second, to what extent can the current findings be interpreted as evidence of exposure effects, rather than affect-conditioned reporting or recall? Third, are baseline-adjusted models sufficient for the project's panel structure, or would alternative analytic strategies better capture these relationships? Fourth, should the paper concentrate more explicitly on out-party processes, given that the in-party interaction pattern is weak and not statistically significant?

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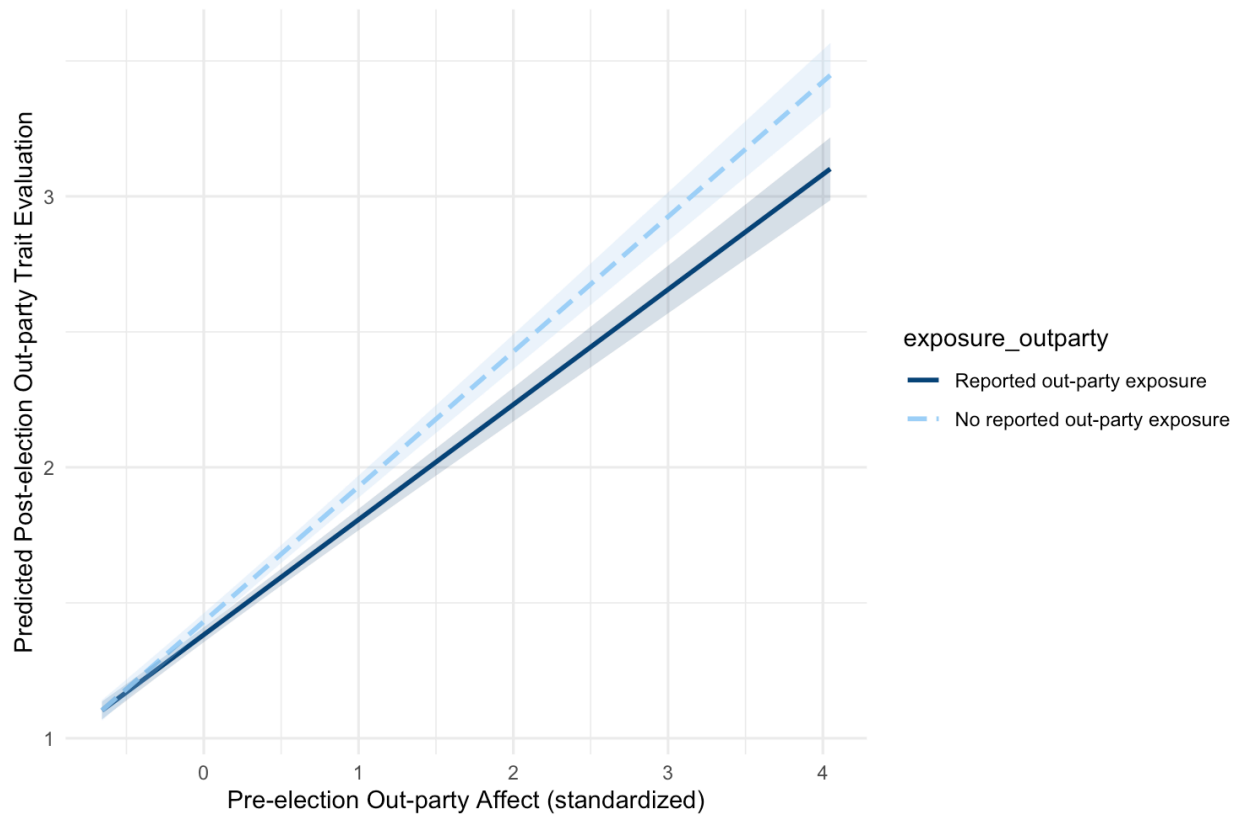
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**Figure 1**

*Interaction Between Pre-election Out-party Affect and Reported Out-party Exposure Predicting Post-election Out-party Trait Evaluation*



*Note.* Lines represent predicted values from weighted regression models. Pre-election out-party affect is standardized. Reported out-party exposure is coded as 0 = no reported exposure and 1 = reported exposure. Shaded areas indicate 95% confidence intervals. Models include baseline controls for pre-election out-party evaluation and are estimated with survey weights and robust standard errors.